

INTRODUCTION · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

AWS Certified Solutions Architect – Associate

SAA-C03. A complete exam-focused course, built from the official AWS exam guide and documentation.

EXAM SAA-C03 MODULES 23 PRACTICE QUESTIONS 100

Every scenario here is **original**. Nothing was copied from a question bank.

What the exam is

- ◆ **65 questions in 130 minutes.** Fifty are scored. Fifteen are unscored trial questions, and they are not marked.
- ◆ **Two formats.** Multiple choice with one right answer, and multiple response with two or more correct out of five or more.
- ◆ **Scaled score 100 to 1000. You pass at 720.**
- ◆ **Compensatory scoring.** You do not need to pass each domain. Only the overall result counts.
- ◆ **No penalty for guessing.** An unanswered question is simply wrong, so never leave one blank.

ON THE EXAM

Two minutes per question. That budget shapes every strategy in this course.

The four domains, and where your time goes

DOMAIN	EXAM WEIGHT	COURSE TIME
Design Secure Architectures	30%	3 modules
Design Resilient Architectures	26%	3 modules
Design High-Performing Architectures	24%	3 modules
Design Cost-Optimized Architectures	20%	3 modules
Cross-cutting skills	not a domain	2 modules
Practice exams	not a domain	4 exams

ON THE EXAM

Security is the largest domain. It is also where most people lose marks.

The twenty-three modules

SECTION	MODULES	RUNTIME
Introduction	Module 0	8 min
Domain 1 - Secure	Modules 1 to 3	58 min
Domain 2 - Resilient	Modules 4 to 6	55 min
Domain 3 - High-Performing	Modules 7 to 9	60 min
Domain 4 - Cost-Optimized	Modules 10 to 12	44 min
Cross-cutting skills	Modules 13 to 17	77 min
Five practice exams	Modules 18 to 22	109 min

ON THE EXAM

Domain time is proportional to exam weight, so the hours you spend match the marks on offer.

Availability warnings you need up front

The exam catalogue lags the real AWS catalogue. Sometimes by years.

- ◆ **Elastic Transcoder** was discontinued in November 2025. It is still on the official in-scope list.
- ◆ **S3 Select and S3 Glacier Select** closed to new customers in July 2024.
- ◆ **Aurora Serverless v1** reached end of life in March 2025. Version two was later renamed to just Aurora Serverless.
- ◆ **QuickSight** became Amazon Quick Suite, then Amazon Quick. The exam guide still lists the old name.

ON THE EXAM

Answer from the documented exam catalogue, not from what you can buy today.

How to actually use this course

01

Watch in order

Later modules assume vocabulary from earlier ones.

02

Pause and commit

On every scenario, choose an answer before the walkthrough.

03

Sit exam one

After module seventeen. Note which domain your misses cluster in.

04

Rewatch the weak domain

Only that one. Not the whole course.

05

Space the rest

Exams two, three and four over following days, not in one sitting.

ON THE EXAM

Revising what you already know feels productive and moves nothing.

What you are assumed to know already

AWS suggests about one year of hands-on design experience. Here is what that means in practice.

- ◆ **Basic networking.** What a subnet is, what a route table does, the difference between public and private addressing.
- ◆ **Client-server basics.** What a load balancer does, roughly what happens when a browser requests a page.
- ◆ **General database literacy.** Relational versus key-value, and why one scales differently from the other.
- ◆ **Not required.** Coding ability, Linux administration, or prior AWS certifications.

ON THE EXAM

If subnets and route tables are genuinely new, spend a weekend on networking first. Everything in domain one depends on it.

The anatomy of an SAA question

01

The setup

A company, a workload, some existing architecture.

02

The problem

Something is slow, costly, exposed or fragile.

03

The constraint

The sentence that eliminates two options. Easy to skim past.

04

The qualifier

MOST cost-effective. LEAST operational overhead. This is the real question.

05

The options

Usually two that work, one that nearly works, one that does not.

ON THE EXAM

Read the qualifier first, then the question, then the options. It reframes everything.

What this exam is really testing

IT IS NOT TESTING

Recall of service facts

- Memorised service limits and quotas
- Whether you can recite feature lists
- Knowing every service AWS sells
- Command syntax or console clicks

IT IS TESTING

Selection under constraints

- Reading a scenario for the deciding constraint
- Choosing between four plausible services
- Trading cost against effort against resilience
- Recognising when the impressive answer is wrong

THE TIEBREAKER

Nearly every question gives you two answers that would work. Only one fits the stated constraint.

If two options both work, you have **misread the question**. Go back and find the constraint.